I don’t think I have ever seen a cricket pitch completely deserted from the outside before. Somehow it plays with my imagination, conjuring it to sketch out everything that has happened inside a boundary just like this for nearly 30 years. It’s like I’m watching myself from outside now, every version of myself that has been and gone. I am there as a child, half the size of everyone else, throwing myself around in a bid to somehow make a telling contribution, before sulking my way back to the boundary when I haven’t, head tucked into my chest, kicking the floor.

Then there are the magical moments in Burnley when bowling fast was suddenly gifted into my body, like a wish that I had been praying for so much from that solitary bench, and alone at night in bed, it had finally been granted. I’m bowling for Lancashire, being encouraged by all those heroes to run in as fast as I can, to not worry about anything else. I’m making my debut at the MCG, ill-fitting clothes hanging off me, no name on the back of my shirt. Then there’s all the wickets in those early years, all those famous batters I had imagined to be superheroes just years before, turned inside out into S shapes, their stumps out of the ground.

Then the pain and the tears, the nerves, the searching and the over-thinking. The background changes in my mind – from Burnley to Lord’s, Australia to South Africa, India to Pakistan – each setting changing in every way imaginable, the cricket inside still the same. I am there, holding the Ashes urn, at first once, then for a fourth time, before sitting on the outfield with each generation of teammates, our families too, sharing what happened, laughing into the fading light as we re-enact what we have just done.

With it all behind me, my career only a day old but somehow an ocean and a river between me and it now, I feel like I’m treading water in this unknown space. It’s as if it all happened without effort, like it was always meant to. But I remind myself that every single day required effort. I don’t want to forget the conscious energy it took to wake up and make the choice. To choose to try and improve, to choose to reach inside of myself, however painful, and find something that took me beyond where I had been before. I was always searching for that feeling, that perfection. As good as I got, I never reached it. There was always something else to find. That’s why I would never have retired by my own decision. I could never turn my back on all that. The curiosity, the hunger, the love, could never be dimmed and,